managed to force out of his mouth. Dropping Steve Harmison and Matthew Hoggard was barely thinkable. I am careful not to catch anyone's eyes when I leave to join the squad, not the very young Stuart Broad's to my right, or the legendary Hoggard and Harmison to my left. I don't know Stuart well yet. Aside from meeting him at the World Cup last year, we'd shared a moment when, against all odds, we'd won a game there with the bat. I remember seeing that striking blond hair and bottomless blue eyes staring back at me, and thinking, *God, she's beautiful*. We get back into the nets, the hammer blow just dealt, and we are sheepishly ushered into the first team net, Hoggard and Harmison in the other. Steve Harmison does not say anything to us, he just gets a ball and runs in as fast as he can at the poor squad batters at the other end. I'd hardly ever seen him bowl so quickly. He made his thoughts about it all known without having to say a single word.

In 1855, an unexpected earthquake in Wellington left enough flattened-out ground to build a cricket pitch. Between two mountains – Mount Victoria and Mount Cook – it left, by a strange quirk of nature, a dug-in valley that fitted a cricket pitch almost perfectly. The natural sun trap it created protected the ground amongst extremely high winds. At first a swampy marshland, the prisoners in the barracks next to Mount Cook were sent for labour and drained and flattened it, in time calling it the 'Basin Reserve'. It was slowly carved, painstakingly and lovingly into a cricket pitch – hosting games since 1868.

We bat first on day one and, having just watched us bat all day, I run on to the outfield at the end of the first day, needing to release the nervous energy of the responsibility ahead of me and the always sickening wait to bat. We play football after just to unwind. I am slightly full of it, in a bit of a daydream, spraying the ball around, drifting on a bit of a cloud. I receive the ball and, zigzagging amongst batters who have done a day's graft and are more tired than I am, attempt to switch play in one move. I Cruyff turn suddenly. My ankle rolls underneath me. The ball is lost and I suddenly feel a visceral pain. I can't walk. I've done something quite bad, I think? Humiliated and nervous that I have done some sort of serious damage that will rule me out, I have crutches brought out to take me off the pitch. I sleep with ice over the top of it and wake to a throbbing, swollen ankle.

I get to the ground in quite a lot of pain and the staff tell me, under no circumstances whatsoever can I bowl. I sit there, looking out at the people